

Four-year-old Devyani (*name changed*) could hardly contain her excitement when told she would be going to school on February 21. She had joined kindergarten last year in a South Delhi school, but could attend classes only online, where she would first greet her teacher and then every one of her classmates. However, when her father took her to first day of school and her class teacher came out to meet her, Devyani shrank back, and asked her father, "Where did she come from?" Having seen her teacher only on a computer screen, the young child had trouble dealing with her in person.

Covid wasn't easy for eight-year-old Tara (*name changed*) either. While her architect parents were busy working from home, she would kill time watching cartoon shows and consuming packet after packet of chips, biscuits, Maggi noodles and other junk food. By the time her parents realised their daughter had a problem, she had piled on a whopping 10 kilos during the lockdown. "It affected her studies and she became reluctant to attend online classes," recalls her mum. "When we took her to the doctor and had blood tests done, we were told she was low on several vitamins and essential minerals." Putting Tara on a healthy diet proved a big challenge—junk food had become the lonely child's comfort food.

In Mumbai, 12-year-old Aditya (*name changed*) grappled with a problem of a different sort during Covid. When he had an argument with a classmate at Bombay Scottish, the latter blocked Aditya on all social media—Whatsapp, Facebook and Instagram. "Offline, I could have found a way to speak to him and clear the air," says Aditya. Meanwhile, his younger brother Abhay read up so much on Covid on the smartphone his dad gave him that he started having nightmares. "He became so scared of Covid he would not let us eat outside food," says his mum Divyangana, who had a hard time battling one child's depression and the other's fears.

Covid may be receding, but the scars it has left behind on Gen Alpha—children born strictly in the decade just gone by—may well be permanent. You could just as well call them Generation Covid, given that the SARS-CoV-2 virus hijacked almost the entire Greek alphabet. They seem to have paid the heaviest price for safety during the pandemic, and even as things return to normality, or a new normal, if you will, their lives will forever be coloured by the alternate reality they have inhabited in the past two years.

Schools in India have been closed for 100 weeks since the lockdown in March 2020, though some schools and higher classes opened intermittently. It left close to 250 million children affected, as a 2021 Unicef study for India estimated, whether in learning outcomes or emotionally, physically and socially—manifesting in disturbed sleep patterns, increased anxiety, eating disorders or deficiencies in social skills.

Two groups of children were most seriously affected, according to Dr Hirak Patel, a psychologist at the Fortis Hospital in Mulund, Mumbai. The first, she says, were those who had never been to school. With the foundation of their learning and socialisation beginning on a screen, they never got to experience the excitement of a classroom or sharing in group activities on the